‘Why my battalion, sir,’ was my query.

‘The GOC thinks highly of you and your battalion, and he feels that you would be the best person to execute the mission involving this new concept,’ replied Lieutenant Colonel Uban.

I promptly spoke to my brigade commander, Brigadier Ved Airy, who told me to disregard any orders that came directly from the Division HQ. I had an uncanny feeling that my battalion and I were likely to get embroiled in this personality clash between my immediate boss, and his boss. And that too, just because we were doing well professionally, and were counted amongst the best battalions!

Armies all over the world are hierarchical organizations. Violation of the chain of command is taken as interference and undermining of the authority of the subordinate commanders. I presumed that my brigade commander did not appreciate direct orders being given to me by the Division HQ, bypassing the Brigade HQ, and rightly so, too.

Therefore, Brigadier Airy picked up the phone and called up the GOC, Major General Mayadas. The conversation went something like this:

‘Sir, I am given to understand by Colonel J.J. Singh that you wish to see him regarding the imminent exercise with troops,’ queried the brigadier.

‘Yes, I wanted to brief him about his task during the exercise. I would like 9 Maratha LI to execute the mobile defence concept,’ the GOC replied.

‘Sir, I may be wrong, but I was under the impression that it was my responsibility to conduct this exercise?’ said Brigadier Airy.

‘But of course, Ved. It’s your exercise,’ admitted the general grudgingly.

‘In that case, please let me decide the specific missions for my battalions, and which one would act as Blue or Redland. Further, I would request that no direct orders are conveyed by your staff to my units, sir,’ Brigadier Airy emphasized.

‘Okay, Brigadier Airy, do as you like,’ said the general in a gruff tone. Ved Airy put the J7[1] field telephone on its cradle with a